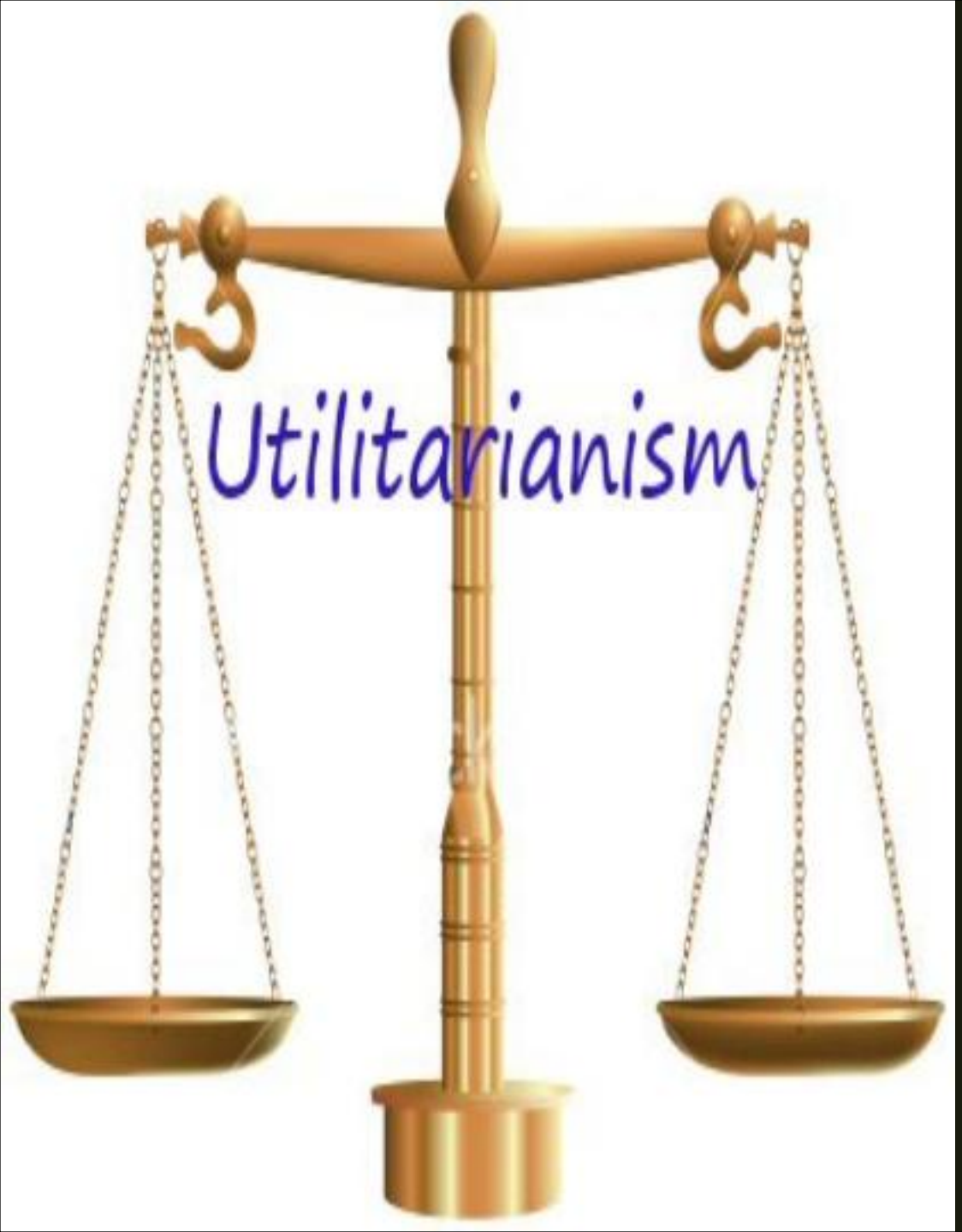


AT THE END OF THE LESSON, THE STUDENTS SHOULD BE ABLE TO:

1. DISCUSS THE BASIC AND SIGNIFICANT FEATURES OF THE ETHICS OF UTILITARIANISM;
2. ASSESS THE STRENGHTS AND WEAKNESSES OF UTILITARIAN ETHICS; AND
3. APPLY THE UTILITARIAN CONCEPTS TO THE ANALYSIS OF VARIOUS ETHICAL ISSUES.

THE BASIC AND SIGNIFICANT FEATURES OF THE ETHICS OF UTILITARIANISM

THE BASIC AND SIGNIFICANT FEATURES OF THE ETHICS OF UTILITARIANISM

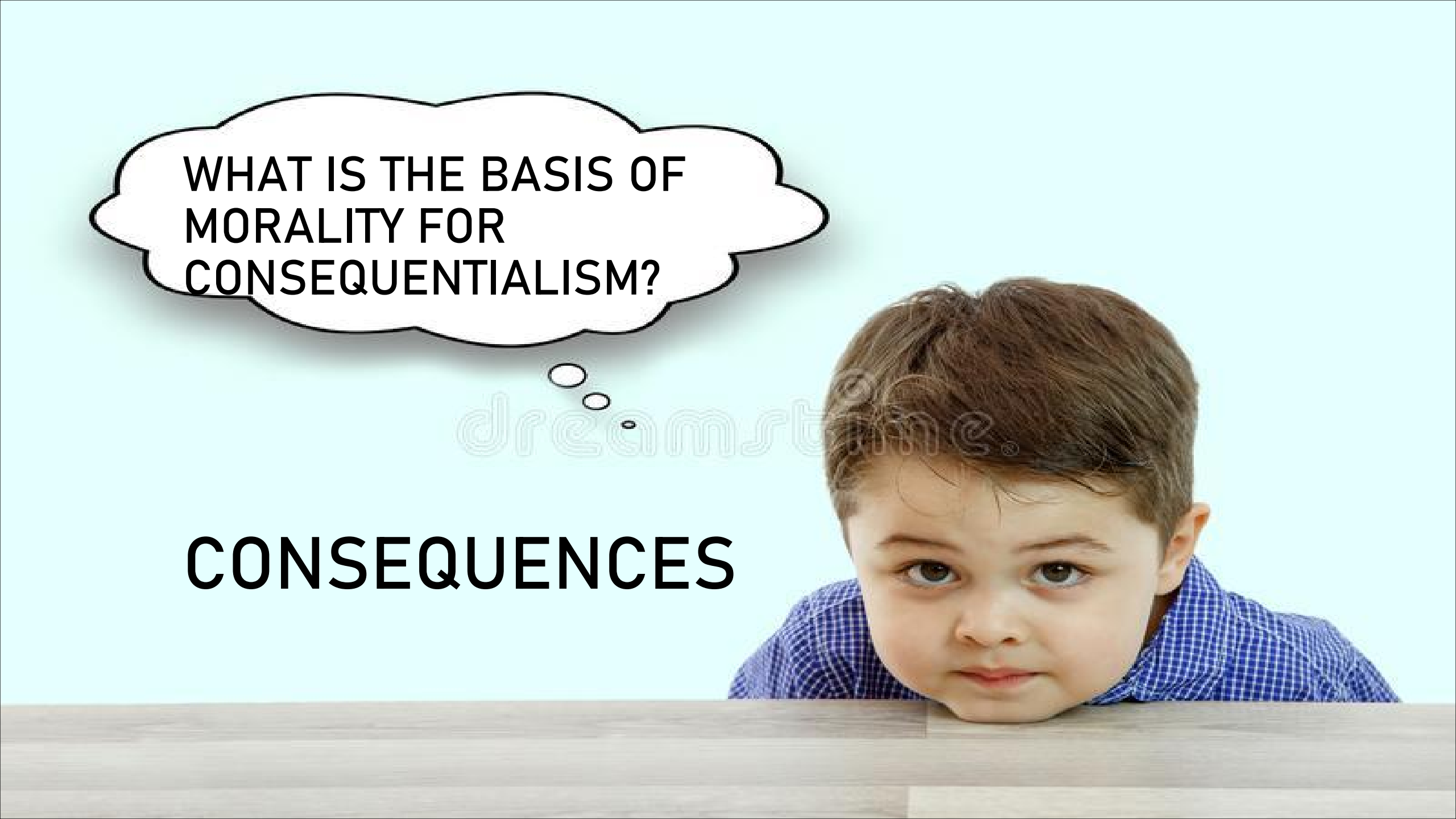
A. CONSEQUENTIALISM
B. ETHICAL HEDONISM
C. THE PRINCIPLE OF UTILITY
D. THE GREATEST GOOD FOR THE GREATEST NUMBER

A. CONSEQUENTIALISM

- An ethical theory that claims, to assess whether an act is good or bad, one should look into the outcome of the act.
- What solely matters is the result of the deed, not the deed itself.
- Consequentialists think that **the ends justify the means.**
- If the end result (consequences) of an action are good, this justifies the means (action) that we took to achieve the end.

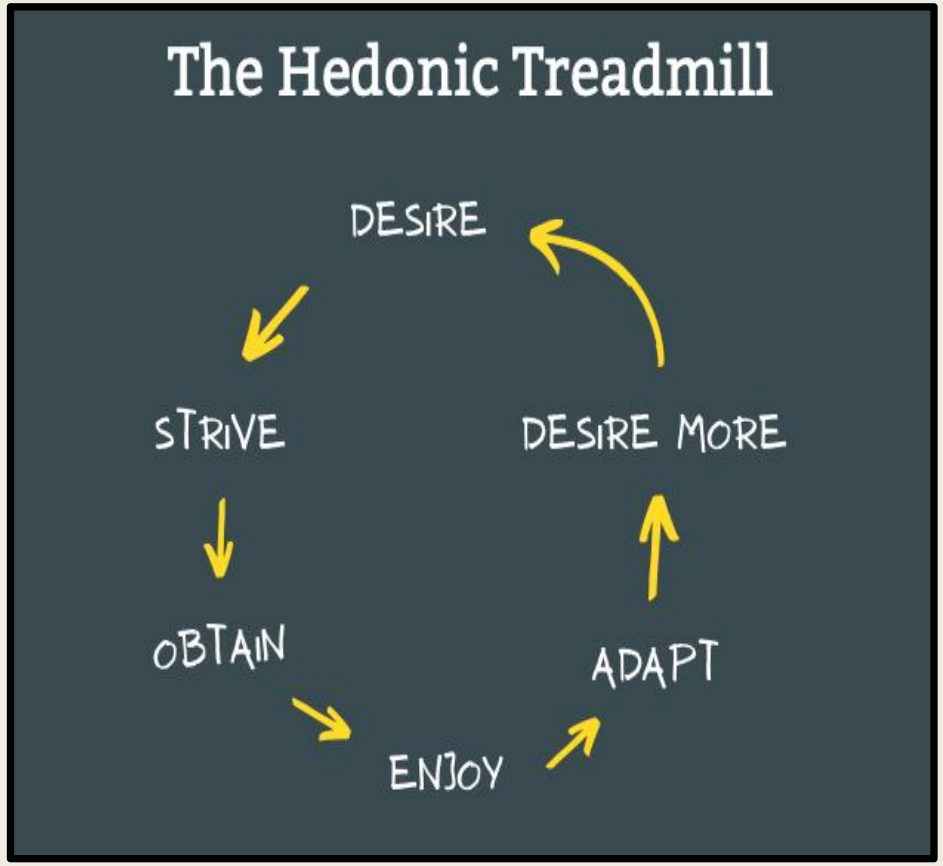
LIKE CONSEQUENTIALISM, UTILITARIANISM PLAINLY DISREGARDS THE ACT ITSELF AS THE BASIS OF MORALITY BECAUSE…

- No action in itself can be considered as good or bad, apart from its outcome or end. Action does not have intrinsic value.
- Action is only viewed as a mere instrument to achieve something. It is not an end in itself.


WHAT IS THE BASIS OF MORALITY FOR CONSEQUENTIALISM?
CONSEQUENCES

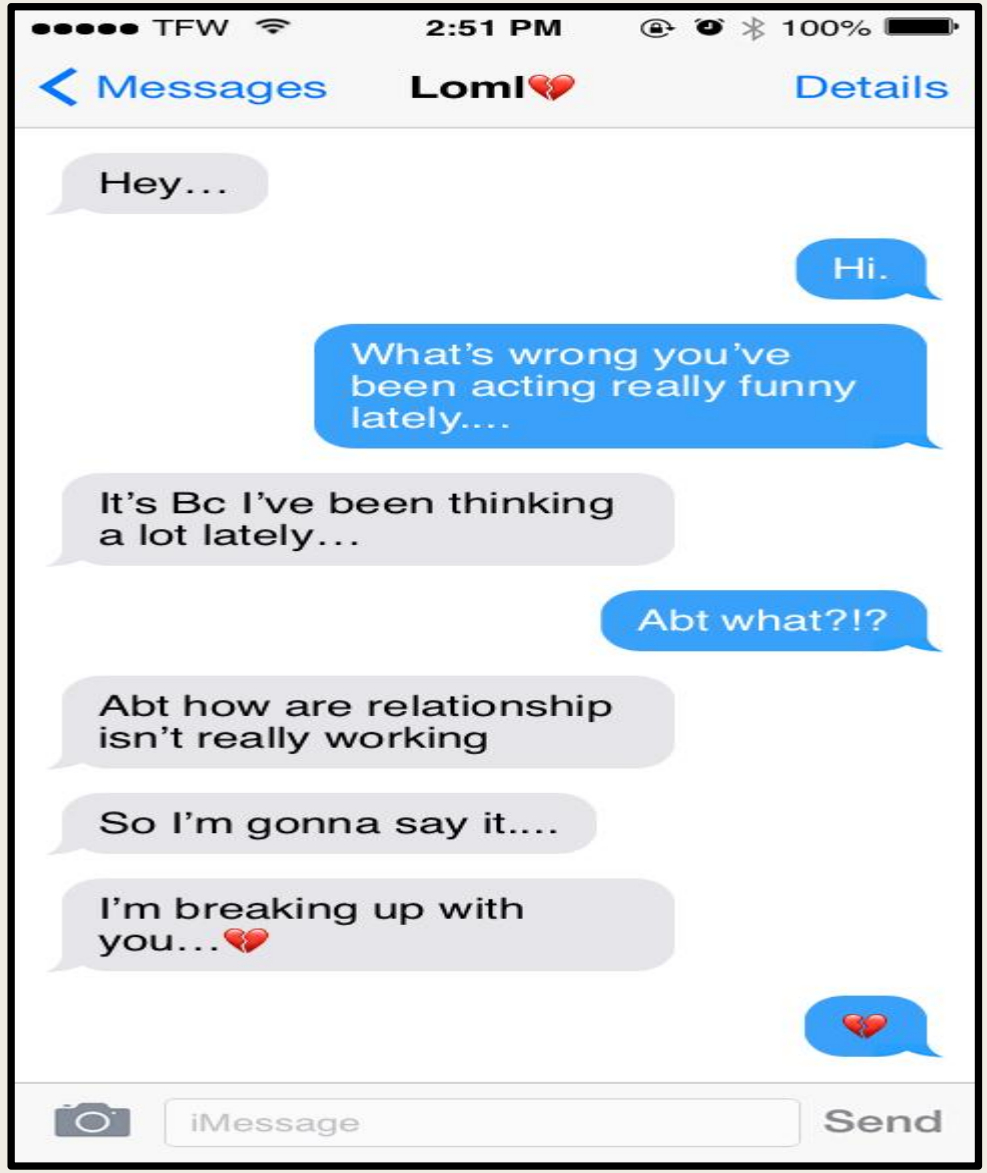
B. ETHICAL HEDONISM

- An ethical theory which holds that the supreme end of man consists in **the acquisition of pleasure**, without infringing the rights of others.
  - ✓ pleasurable is good
  - ✓ pain is evil
- Hence, morality is grounded on the pleasure that an act brings.
  - ✓ sensible pleasures are the highest good of life



LIKE HEDONISM, UTILITARIANISM CLAIMS THAT PAIN AND SUFFERING SHOULD BE AVOIDED WHEN ONE IS THINKING ABOUT DOING SOMETHING.

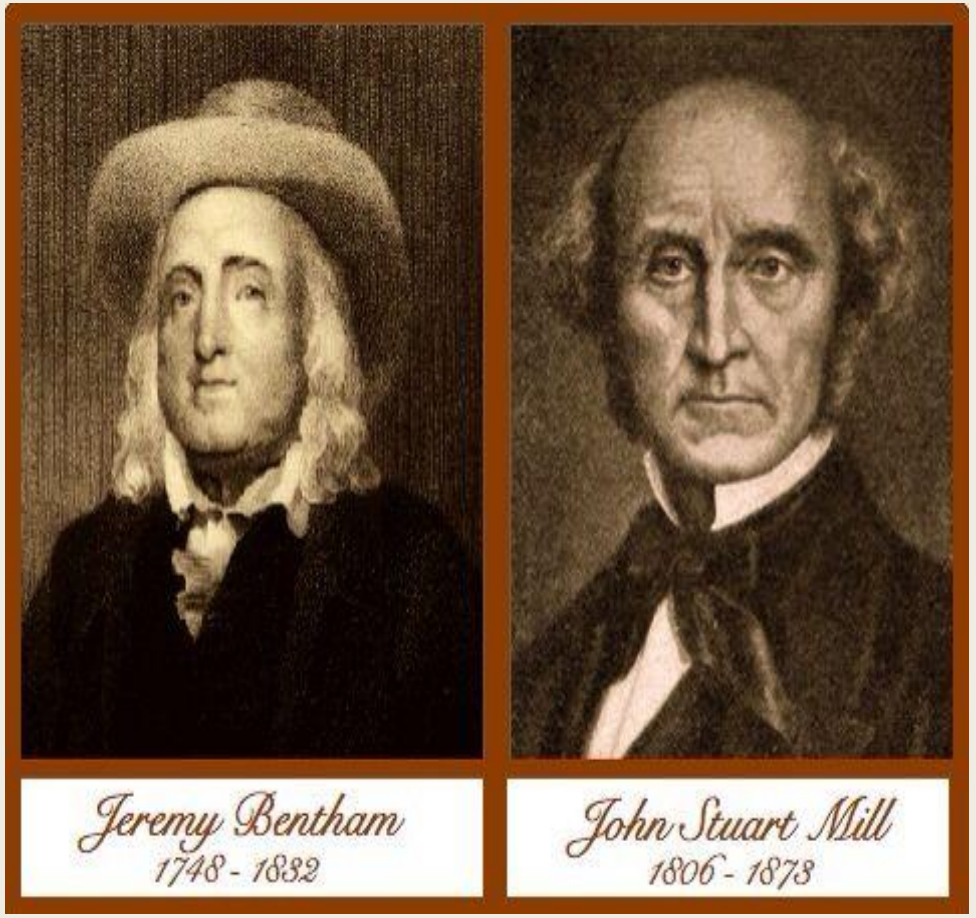
- Right and wrong are dependent on the pleasure or pain that an act will bring or result to.
- If an act produces pleasure, it is considered right or good; If it results to pain, it is considered wrong or bad.



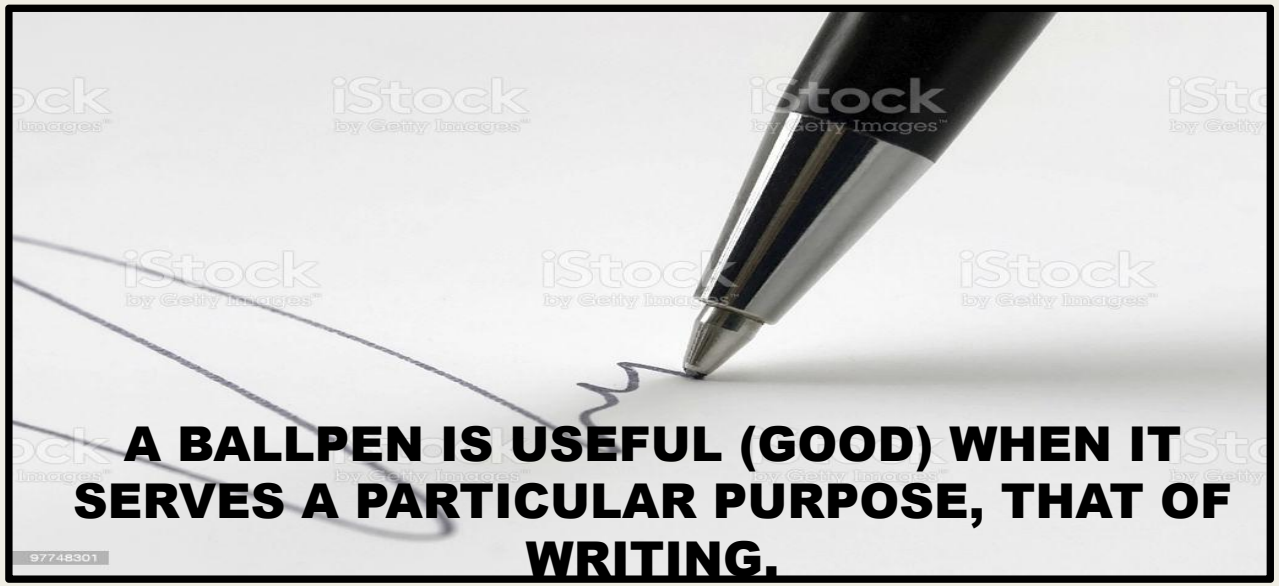
WHAT IS THE BASIS OF MORALITY FOR HEDONISM?
PLEASURES

C. THE PRINCIPLE OF UTILITY

- The name of utilitarianism is derived from the Latin “utilis”, meaning “useful”.
- It was Bentham who specifically coined the phrase “principle of utility” **to denote that the essentially determining element whether an act can be good or right is its utility or usefulness.**



BY UTILITY IS MEANT THAT PROPERTY IN ANY OBJECT, WHEREBY IT TENDS TO PRODUCE BENEFIT, ADVANTAGE, PLEASURE, GOOD OR HAPPINESS OR TO PREVENT THE HAPPENING OF MISCHIEF, PAIN, EVIL, OR UNHAPPINESS TO THE PARTY, WHOSE INTEREST IS CONSIDERED (**BENTHAM, 1976**)

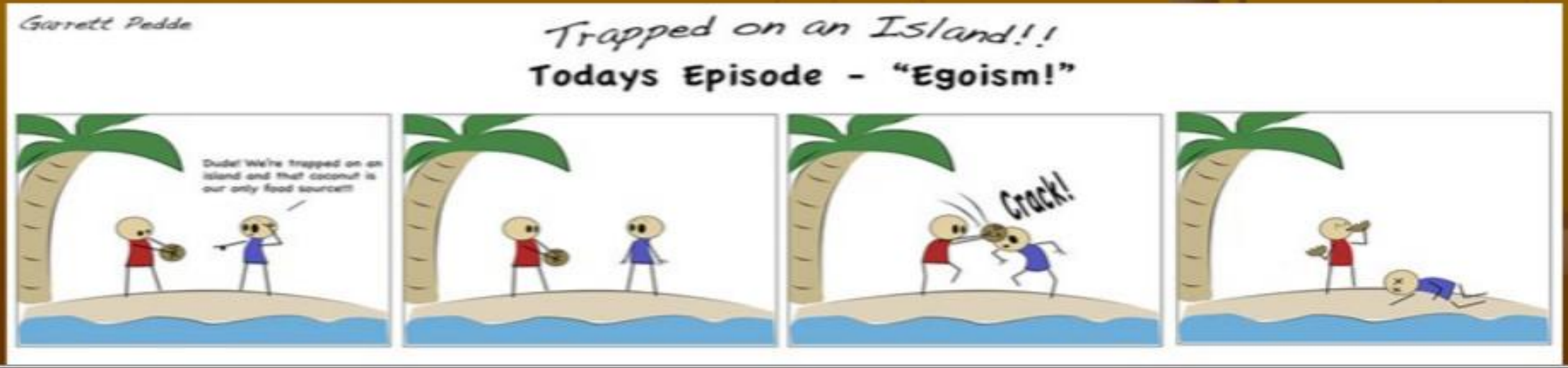


WHEN IS OUR ACTION BECOME USEFUL?

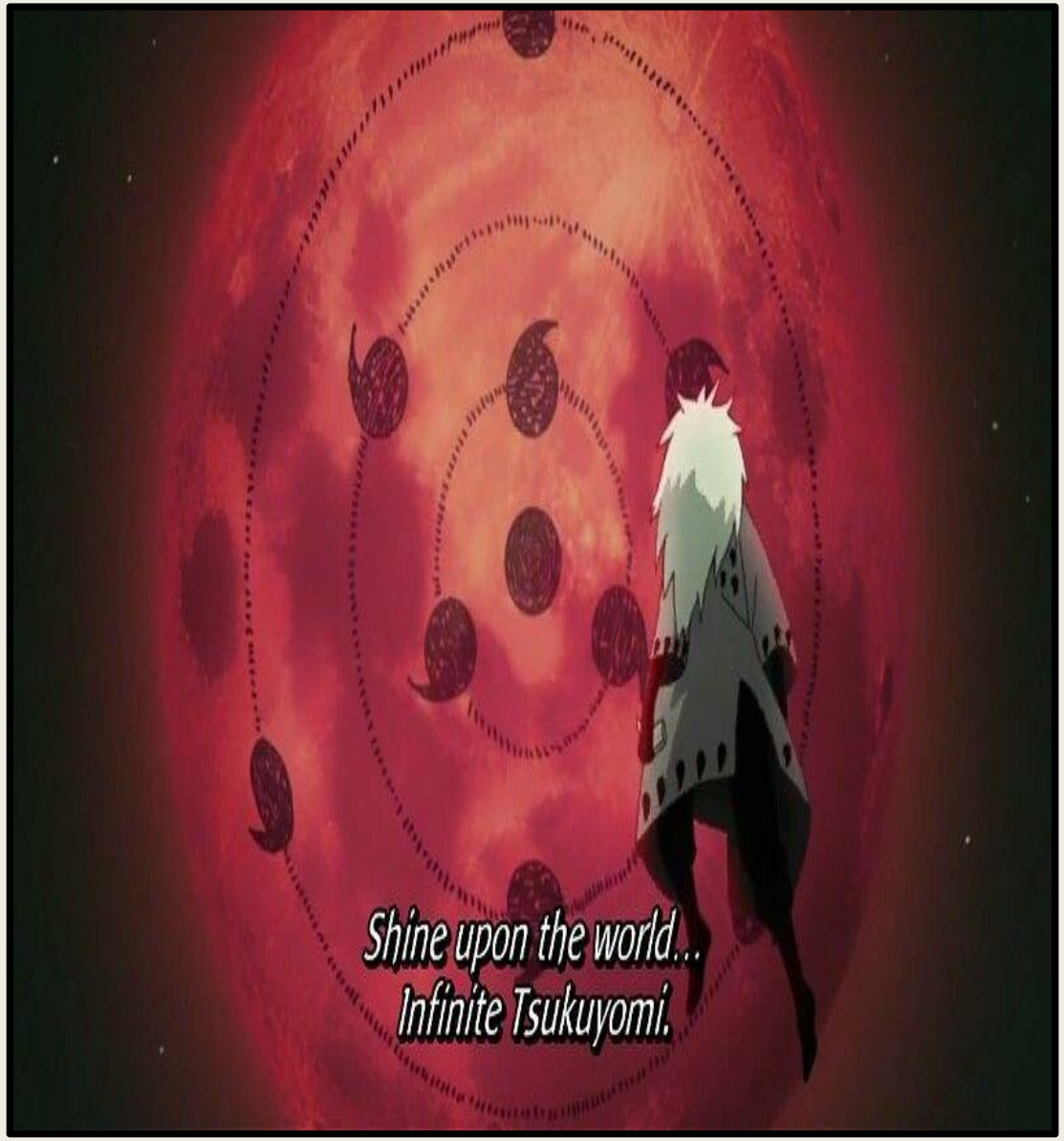
WHEN IT PRODUCES HAPPINESS (DESIRABLE CONSEQUENCE), NOT ONLY FOR ONESELF **BUT ALSO FOR OTHERS**

Egoism

- This is a consequentialist theory that contends that we act morally when we act in a way that promotes our own best long-term interests. Therefore when deciding the morality of an action, we should only consider the consequences for ourselves.



THAT IS WHY TO AIM AT GOOD AND DESIRABLE CONSEQUENCES OR RESULTS DOES NOT MAKE ONE AUTOMATICALLY AS A UTILITARIAN.



D. THE GREATEST GOOD FOR THE GREATEST NUMBER

- The best action is the one that leads to the greatest amount of happiness **for the greatest number of people.**
- What makes utilitarianism so appealing to a lot of people is its special emphasis on the social dimension of morality.

Utilitarianism

The best action is the one that leads to the greatest amount of happiness for the greatest number of people.

Save the Woman?

She's a good person, has 4 kids, neighbors love her, and she helps lots of people.

Saving the woman makes sense.

Shouldn't Batman kill the Joker? He doesn't kill.

Kill the Joker?

He's killed many people and will kill many more. He has no friends. He's hated.

HOW DO WE MEASURE PLEASURE AND PAIN, HAPPINESS AND UNHAPPINESS?

Bentham's Felicific Calculus

Pleasure can be `scientifically' calculated according to the following 7 criteria of the Felicific Calculus

1. DURATION	How long will it last?	The longer the pleasure lasts, the better.
2. INTENSITY	How intense is it?	The more intense the pleasure, the better.
3. PROPINQUITY	How near or remote?	The nearer, closer or more often that pleasures occur, the better.
4. EXTENT	How widely it covers	The greater the number of people who can experience pleasure, the better.
5. CERTAINTY	How probable is it?	The more certain the pleasure, the better.
6. PURITY	How free from pain is it?	The purer the pleasure, the better.
7. FECUNDITY	Lead to further pleasure?	The greater the possibility that the pleasure that one can derive from an act will be followed by more pleasures, the better.

- THE MAIN GOAL OF BENTHAM IN FORMULATING THIS METHOD IS TO HELP INDIVIDUALS AS WELL AS LAWMAKERS AND LEGISLATORS DECIDE WHAT OUGHT TO BE DONE IN ANY GIVEN SET OF CIRCUMSTANCES.
- IN ETHICAL OR MORAL DECISION-MAKING, BENTHAM CLAIMS THAT WHAT TRULY MATTERS IN THE END IS THE MAXIMIZATION OF PLEASURE OR HAPPINESS AND THE MINIMIZATION IF NOT THE TOTAL ERADICATION OF PAIN OR SUFFERING.

Two Type of Pleasures: Quantity vs Quality

- Bentham's formulation of the hedonic calculus to provide a quantitative calculation of the value of different pleasures where decisions are made into a simple exercise of addition and deduction at arriving at the final balance put him (rightly or wrongly) under the level of a psychological hedonist.
- Jeremy Bentham advocated a quantitative hedonism in order to assess the moral worth of an action- it being good as far as it promoted pleasure, and bad as far as it promoted pain.
- Quantitative Hedonism is often accused of over-valuing animalistic, simple, and debauched pleasures.

- Mill introduces a way of determining pleasure that is not just confined to quantity or amount but more on its quality.
- Mill claims that pleasure are of two types: quantity and quality.
- Pleasures differ not just in amount but also in quality.Pleasures of the mind or the spirit are higher than pleasures of the flesh and of the body.
- Accordingly for Mill, persons should seek the higher pleasure than pursue the lower kind that is associated with mere sensual satisfaction or fulfillment.

It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied.

(John Stuart Mill)

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THE STRENGHTS AND WEAKNESSES OF UTILITARIAN ETHICS

UTILITARIANISM: THE END JUSTIFIES THE MEANS.
PROBLEM: THE END DOES NOT JUSTIFY THE MEANS. AN ACT IS NOT AUTOMATICALLY GOOD SIMPLY BECAUSE IT HAS A GOOD GOAL.

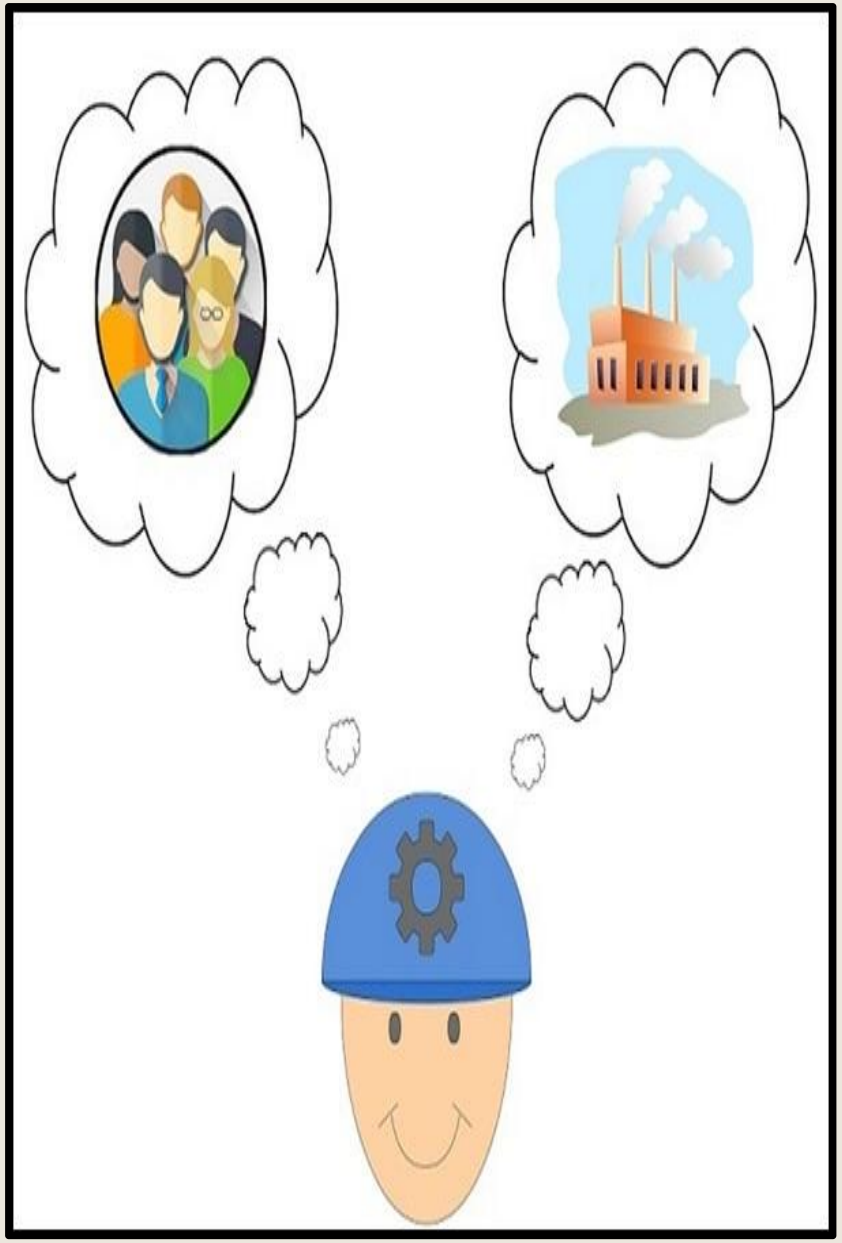
UTILITARIANISM: GREATEST GOOD FOR THE GREATEST NUMBER
PROBLEM: IF FORCED TO CHOOSE TO SAVE EITHER A MEDICAL DOCTOR OR A POOR CHILD FROM A DESTRUCTIVE HOUSE FIRE, ONE IS OBLIGATED TO SAVE THE MEDICAL DOCTOR BECAUSE WE KNOW HE IS ABLE TO HELP PEOPLE; WE DON'T KNOW THE FUTURE OF THE CHILD.

IRONICALLY, ONE OF THE GREATEST STRENGTHS OF UTILITARIANISM – ITS CONCERN FOR COLLECTIVE HUMAN WELFARE – IS ALSO ONE OF ITS GREATEST WEAKNESSES.

IN FOCUSING ON WHAT'S BEST FOR THE GROUP AS A WHOLE, UTILITARIANISM DISCOUNTS THE WORTH OF THE INDIVIDUAL. THE NEEDS OF THE PERSON ARE SUBJUGATED TO THE NEEDS OF THE GROUP OR ORGANIZATION.

EXAMPLE:

THE ENGINEER HAS THE OPPORTUNITY TO SAVE 10 MILLION PESOS ON A DESIGN. BUT HE KNOWS THAT THIS WILL LATER CAUSE AN ACCIDENT KILLING 5 PEOPLE. HE ARGUES THAT 10 MILLION PESOS CAN CAUSE MORE HAPPINESS THAN 5 LIVES.



Act and Rule Utilitariansim

Act utilitarianism (Bentham)

- Looks at the consequences of each individual act and calculates utility each time the act is performed

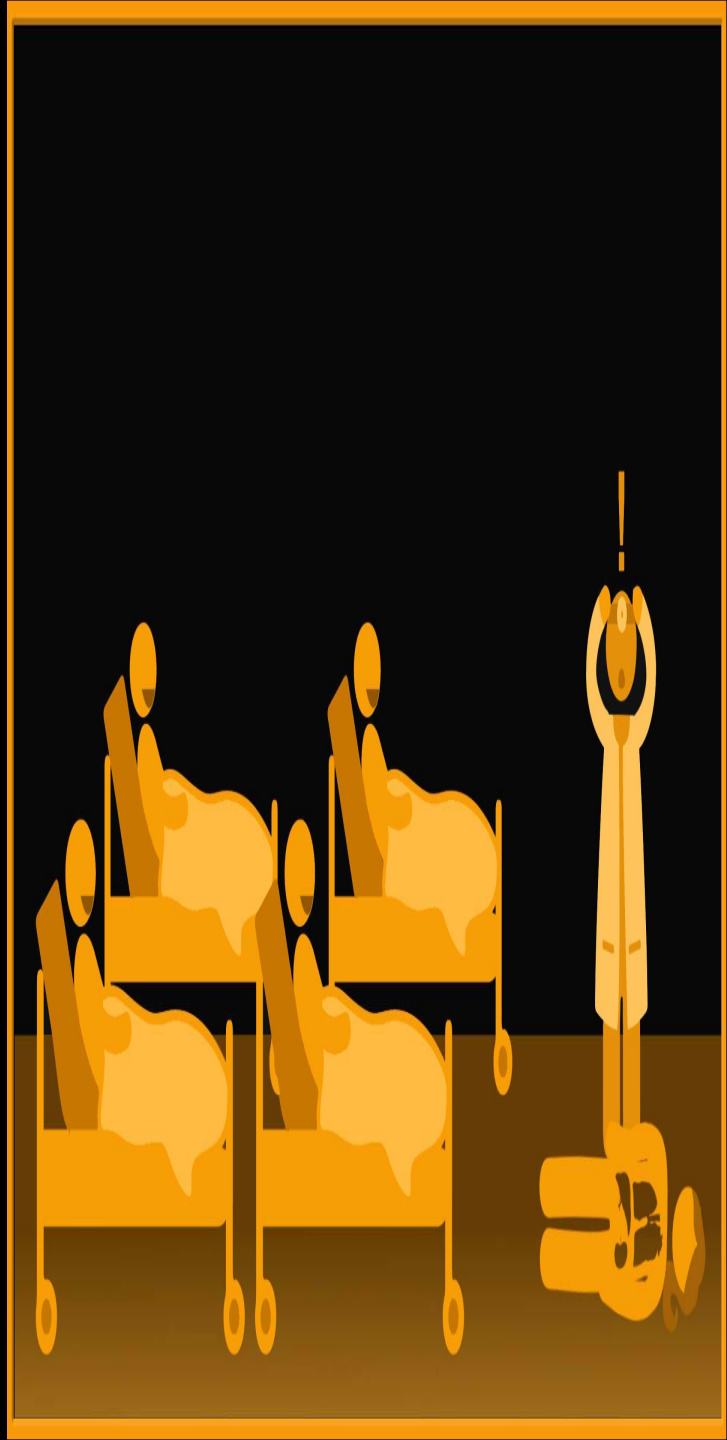
Rule utilitarianism (Mill)

- Looks at the consequences of having everyone follow a particular rule and calculates the overall utility of accepting or rejecting the rule

AN ANALYSIS OF VARIOUS ETHICAL ISSUES

An Ethical Dilemma

- A transplant surgeon has five patients, each in need of a different organ, who will each die without that organ.
- Unfortunately, there are no organs available to perform any of these five transplant operations.
- A healthy young traveler, just passing through the city the doctor works in, comes in for a checkup. During the checkup, the doctor discovers that his organs are compatible with all five of his dying patients.
- Suppose further that if the young man were to disappear, no one would suspect the doctor.
- Do you support the morality of the doctor to kill that tourist and provide his healthy organs to those five dying persons and save their lives?



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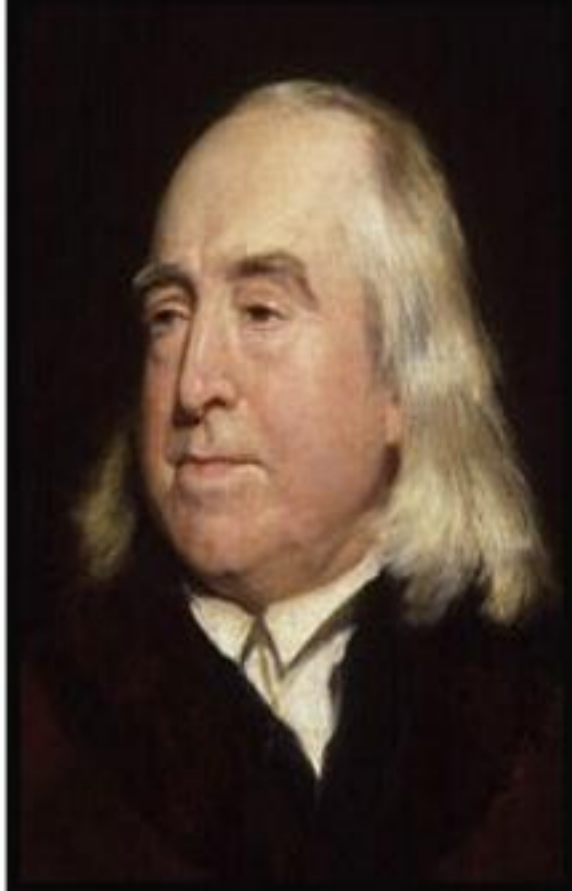

The greatest happiness of the greatest number is the foundation of morals and legislation.

(Jeremy Bentham)

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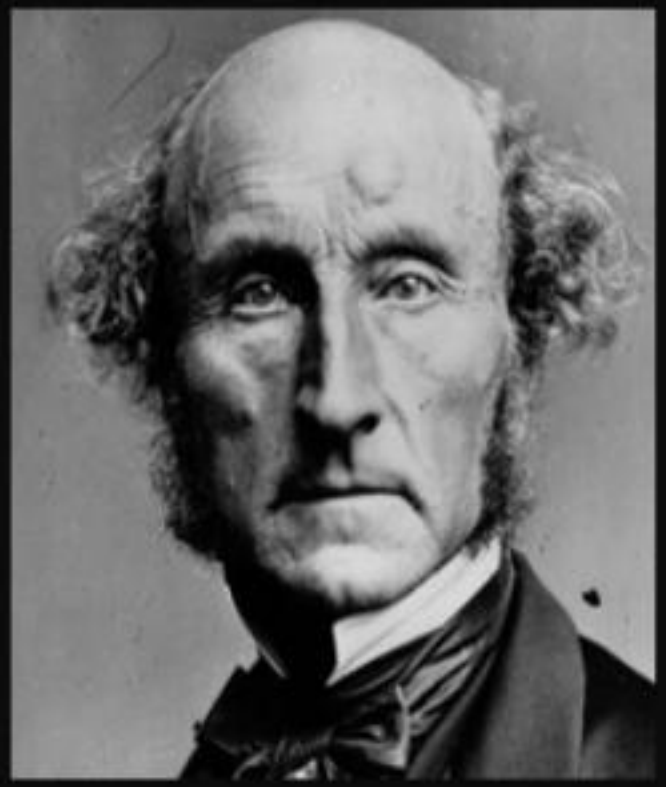
John Stuart Mill



Actions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness; wrong as they tend to produce the reverse of happiness. By happiness is intended pleasure and the absence of pain.

AZ QUOTES